The suggestions having been put on paper, Kaul asked for a helicopter and left his Corps HQ to see if he could find any trace of the withdrawing 62 Brigade that he believed was still fighting its way through towards Dirang Dzong. However, as a helicopter was not available, the corps commander went towards Missamari by road instead. The departure of Kaul meant that Palit had to approach Sen and Thapar who were 'sitting dejectedly on chairs drawn up near a map, staring at it silently, as though waiting for the oracle on the wall to provide a solution to their problems. I managed to break into their reverie only after my second or third attempt.'

Palit briefed Thapar about the orders he had issued for the immediate airlift of 5 Division and obtained the chief's post facto approval. He then suggested that plans be drawn up to oppose the Chinese should they reach the foothills.

The army commander interrupted the DMO: 'Nothing can be done. I have no troops available.'

With Thapar saying nothing, there was a real danger of Sen's pessimism further affecting an already despondent chief. Palit listed the forces available on the north bank of the Brahmaputra. He argued that given the speed and extent of the Chinese advance, there was no way the enemy could muster enough troops for a concentrated thrust. 'There is plenty that we can do—and will do,' Palit said.

However, Sen wasn't buying any of the arguments. Turning to Thapar, he said: 'Sir, there is no option left for us but to ask for a ceasefire!'

'What?' blurted out an incredulous Palit, 'Surrender?'

'If it comes to that, I suppose, yes.'

The Chief of Army Staff looked grimly at the Eastern Army Commander. He had nothing to say. Everybody else in the Ops Room just stared at the two officers.

Finally, it was Palit who found his voice: 'Never,' he said, 'if the Chinese come down into the plains, that's the time to get our own back at them—not put our hands up!'

Just then news came that the Chinese had engaged Bomdila and that there had been casualties among 1 Sikh LI that was manning the defences. Palit took the telephone and was put through to Bomdila but at that point no one could tell him where Gurbax Singh was. It was 3.30 p.m. and Thapar had had enough—he said he had to return immediately to Delhi and ordered Palit to get the aircraft ready. Palit asked to stay on in Tezpur but Thapar